offered special facilities and training. From there students could move on to attend higher education in Sports Training to prepare for international competitions. In the early grades, physical education focuses on movement and gymnastics; in the upper grades, team sports become central.

Community-based sport is another pillar of Cuban sport policy. Access to sports was democratized as the exclusive pre-revolutionary private sports clubs were opened to the public. Sporting events were also made free, and participation in sport was guaranteed as a right in the 1976 Constitution. Cubans of all ages are encouraged to participate in exercise through their family doctors (particularly the approximately 30 percent of the population that suffers from hypertension) and through elder programs.

Cuban athletes were soon bringing home significant numbers of Olympic medals, increasing from none in the 1950s to dozens in the 1992, 1996, 2000, 2004, and 2008 games. Cuban runner Alberto Juantorena, who won a historic Olympic double (400m and 800m) in 1976 and went on to become President of the Cuban Athletics Federation and Vice Minister of Sport, exemplified the nationalistic and revolutionary emphasis placed on sports competition in Cuba when asked how winning the medals changed his life: “My main point in this regard was to compete for my country and my people and to receive the support of the entire Cuban society, to carry my flag in whatever competition I was in, the Olympic Games, Pan-American Games. Then I received support from the Government to compete for my country, and to represent Cuba in competition.”[30]

Sport suffered during the Special Period as cutbacks undermined athletic programs, and Cuban athletes faced the increasing lure of defection. Some 50 members of the 1993 Cuban delegation to the Central American and Caribbean Games in Puerto Rico chose to stay there. Baseball heroes Liván and Orlando “El Duque” Hernández were among two dozen or so players recruited by Cuban American agent Joe Cubas. “I’m an enemy of the Cuban government,” Cubas bragged. When Cuban baseball teams travelled, Cubas would be there dangling lucrative offers.[31]